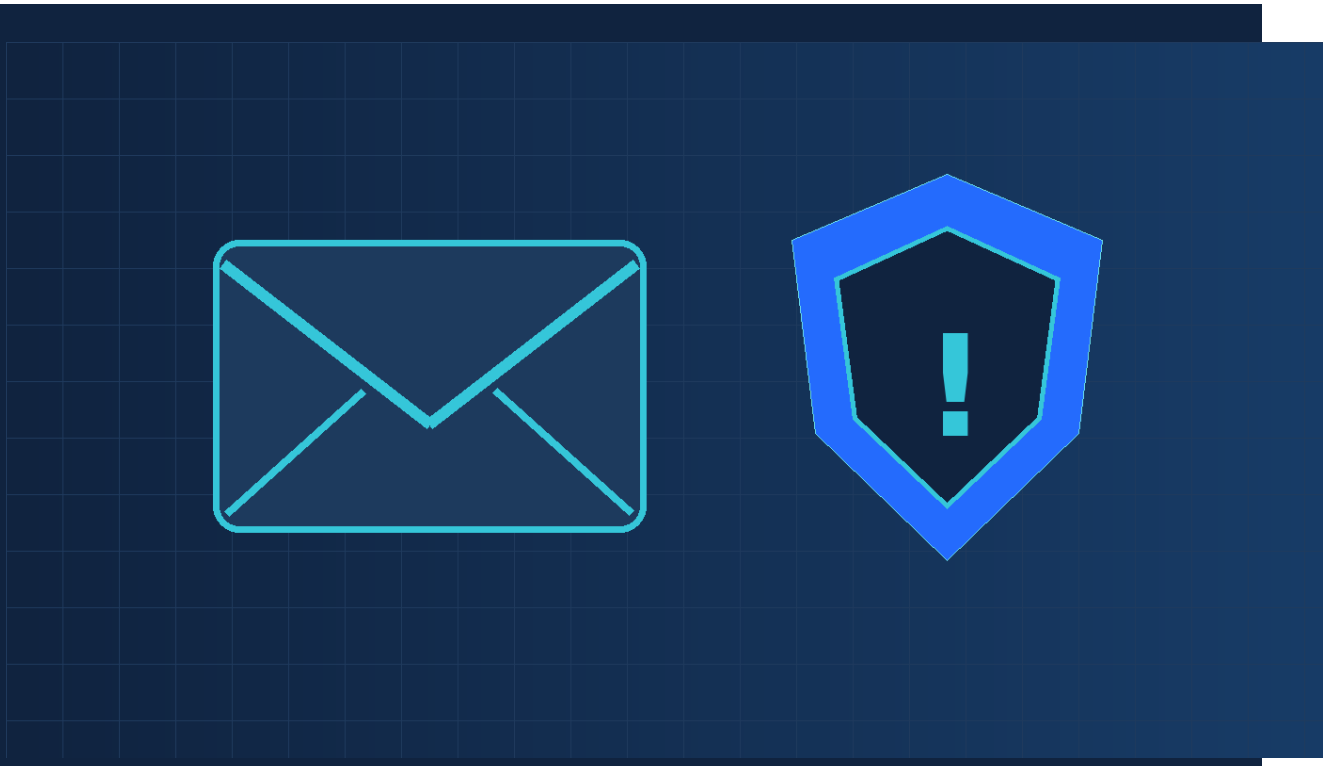


PHISHING DETECTION & AWARENESS REPORT

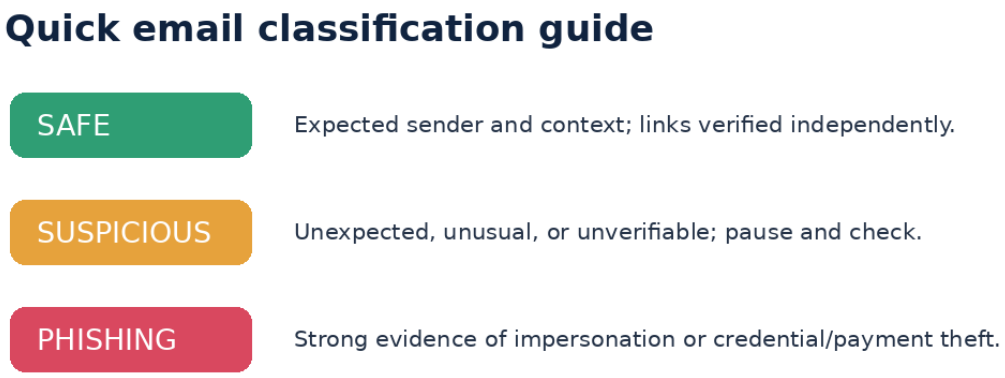
Email threat analysis • Risk classification • User awareness • Prevention guidance

Prepared for: Training / portfolio demonstration
Report date: 16 October 2026
Assessment basis: Synthetic examples for awareness training

IMPORTANT NOTE: This is an educational sample report using fictional email examples and reserved example domains. No real mailbox, email headers, or public dataset was analyzed. Classifications are demonstrations of the decision process, not findings about a real organization.

1. Executive Summary

Phishing is a social-engineering technique in which an attacker impersonates a trusted person or service to persuade someone to reveal information, open a harmful attachment, approve a payment, or visit a deceptive website. This report provides a practical framework for recognizing common indicators and communicating risk clearly.



Key message

No single clue proves that an email is malicious. Check the sender address, message context, links, requests, and any available authentication results together. When uncertain, verify through a separate trusted channel rather than replying to the message.

2. Classification Framework

Label	When to use it	Recommended action
Safe	Expected message, sender identity and context are consistent; links or requests are independently verified.	Proceed cautiously; still follow normal security policy.
Suspicious	Unexpected message, odd wording, unusual request, unfamiliar domain, or evidence is incomplete.	Do not click or reply. Verify with the sender using a known channel; report if unsure.
Phishing	Strong signs of impersonation, credential theft, fake payment instructions, or deceptive links.	Do not interact. Report to IT/security and follow incident-response guidance.

3. Common Phishing Indicators

Spoofed or look-alike sender

The display name may look familiar while the actual email address or domain differs slightly.

Fake or misleading domains

A link may use a misspelling, extra words, misleading subdomain, or unrelated domain. HTTPS/lock icons do not prove a site is legitimate.

Urgency or fear

Messages may threaten account closure, claim a package is blocked, or demand immediate action to reduce careful checking.

Credential or payment request

Unexpected requests for passwords, MFA codes, gift cards, bank changes, or urgent invoice payments deserve independent verification.

Unexpected attachment

Unrequested files, especially executable or macro-enabled documents, can carry risk. Follow organizational policy rather than opening them to investigate.

Authentication anomalies

SPF, DKIM, or DMARC failures can be clues, but results must be interpreted in context. Passing authentication does not guarantee that a message is safe.

4. Example Email Reviews

These examples are fictional. Domains use reserved example names and links are intentionally non-clickable text for training. Do not visit suspicious links to test them.

E-01: Unexpected account verification

PHISHING

Email sample	From: "Example Bank Security" Subject: Immediate action required — account locked Your account will be disabled in 30 minutes. Verify your password and one-time code at: hxxps://login-example.invalid/verify This message is a fictional training example.
Indicators	• Look-alike sender domain uses a digit in place of a letter. • Threatening deadline and account-lockout pressure. • Requests password and one-time code. • Link domain is not independently verified.
Recommended response	Do not click or submit credentials. Report the message. Contact the bank using the official app or the phone number on the card/official website. If credentials were entered, change them from a trusted device and contact the provider.

E-02: Unexpected invoice / payment change

SUSPICIOUS

Email sample	From: "Accounts Team" Subject: Urgent: revised bank details Please pay the attached invoice today. Our bank account has changed. Do not call because the finance team is in meetings. This message is a fictional training example.
Indicators	• Unexpected change to payment details. • Urgency and pressure to bypass normal verification. • Instruction not to call is a strong social-engineering clue. • Attachment was not inspected and should not be opened.
Recommended response	Pause the payment. Verify the change using a previously known vendor contact number and existing approval process. Report the email to finance and security. Never rely only on contact details supplied in the message.

E-03: Routine meeting confirmation

SAFE — EXAMPLE ONLY

Email sample	From: colleague@company.example Subject: Project meeting moved to 2:00 PM The project meeting is now at 2:00 PM in the usual calendar room. Please confirm through the existing calendar invitation. This message is fictional and is not evidence that any real email is safe.
Indicators	• Context is plausible and no credential or payment request appears. • Sender and calendar details still need independent confirmation if unexpected.

Recommended response	Verify the sender and calendar invite if the message was not expected. Do not treat a familiar display name alone as proof. Classification is provisional because the example lacks real headers and mailbox context.

5. Email Header & Link Analysis

Email headers provide routing and authentication information. Review them using an approved email client or trusted header analyzer. Header fields can be forged or confusing; interpret them with the complete message and security-provider results.

Header fields to review

Field	What it can tell you	Caution
From / Reply-To	Whether the displayed sender and reply destination match the expected organization.	Display names are easy to imitate; inspect full addresses.
Return-Path	Envelope sender used for delivery and possible bounce handling.	May legitimately differ for mailing services.
Received	Mail servers that handled the message, read from the bottom upward for route context.	Some lines may be inserted by untrusted systems; trust known receiving infrastructure.
Authentication-Results	SPF, DKIM and DMARC outcomes reported by the receiving mail system.	A pass is not proof of benign intent; a failure is not always proof of phishing.
URLs / redirect chain	Visible destination and possible redirection to another domain.	Do not click suspicious links; use safe organizational tools or a sandboxed analysis workflow.

Safe analysis checklist

1. Preserve the original email using the organization's approved reporting function.
2. Do not forward it to personal accounts or upload confidential messages to public analyzers.
3. Inspect full sender and reply-to addresses, subject, timestamps, and authentication results.
4. Defang suspicious URLs in notes (for example, change `https://` to `hxxps://`) so they are not clickable.
5. Never paste passwords, session tokens, personal information, or confidential message content into public tools.
6. Escalate uncertain or high-impact cases to IT/security.

6. Prevention & Awareness Guidelines

Pause before acting

Treat unexpected urgency, threats, prizes, invoices, and account warnings as reasons to stop and verify.

Verify out of band

Use a known phone number, official app, saved bookmark, or internal directory—not contact details or links in the email.

Protect credentials and MFA

Never share passwords or one-time codes. Use a password manager and phishing-resistant MFA where available.

Inspect links carefully

Check the actual domain, not just link text. Avoid opening unexpected attachments or enabling macros.

Report quickly

Use the organization's phishing-report button or security contact. Early reporting can help block similar messages.

If you clicked

Report immediately, follow IT instructions, change affected credentials from a trusted device, revoke sessions if advised, and contact finance for payment changes.

7. Incident Response Quick Guide

Situation	Immediate response
Received but did not interact	Report it, avoid links/attachments, and delete or quarantine only as directed by policy.
Clicked a link	Stop interacting, report promptly, and tell IT what happened. Do not enter credentials or approve prompts.
Entered password or MFA code	Contact IT/security immediately; change the password using the official site on a trusted device; revoke sessions and review MFA as directed.
Opened attachment / ran a file	Notify IT immediately. Follow containment guidance; do not attempt to clean or investigate the device yourself unless instructed.
Sent money or changed bank details	Contact finance and the bank/payment provider urgently using verified contact information; preserve the email and transaction details.

8. Suggested Awareness Exercise

Run a short tabletop exercise with three messages: a fake account alert, an invoice bank-change request, and an ordinary meeting update. Ask participants to classify each as Safe, Suspicious, or Phishing; identify at least two indicators; and explain what they would do next. Discuss why classification depends on context and why independent verification is essential.

9. Conclusion

Phishing defense combines technical controls with careful user behavior. Encourage employees to pause, verify through a separate trusted channel, protect credentials, and report suspicious messages quickly. The strongest awareness programs make reporting easy and treat early reporting as helpful rather than blameworthy.

Sample reporting message

I received a message that may be phishing. I have not interacted with it / I clicked a link (choose the accurate option). The message arrived at [time] with subject [subject]. Please review the original message and advise whether further action is required. I have not included passwords or other secrets in this report.

Appendix — Portfolio and repository notes

Before publishing a real case study, remove personal data, email addresses, message IDs, internal domains, IP addresses, and sensitive headers. Use synthetic examples or public datasets under their license terms. Never publish live malicious links as clickable URLs. Keep the sample disclaimer unless the report is replaced with a verified, authorized assessment.

Recommended repository structure:
Phishing-Detection-Awareness/
■■■ Phishing_Detection_Awareness_Report.pdf
■■■ README.md
■■■ email_examples.csv
■■■ assets/
■■■ phishing_awareness_cover.png
■■■ classification_guide.png